



MOTION on NOTICE

Submitted at the Regular Park Board Meeting on May 25, 2026

Think Accessible Play: Advancing Vancouver's Second Destination Inclusive Sensory and All-Abilities Park with a Communication Board Pilot at Queen Elizabeth Park

SUBMITTED BY: Commissioner Virdi

WHEREAS

1. Queen Elizabeth Park is Vancouver's highest point and one of the city's premier destination parks, attracting residents and visitors from across the region and internationally;
2. Queen Elizabeth Park contains significant citywide amenities, including Bloedel Conservatory, the Quarry Garden, restaurants, event spaces, and extensive walking paths, but does not currently include a destination playground designed to serve children of varying physical, cognitive, and sensory abilities;
3. The Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation has identified accessibility, inclusion, and equitable access to play as important priorities, and is advancing Vancouver's first destination inclusive sensory play space;
4. Queen Elizabeth Park presents an opportunity to establish Vancouver's second destination inclusive sensory all-abilities park within one of Vancouver's most significant civic parks;
5. The Board has approved new destination attractions at Queen Elizabeth Park, including a proposed zipline and tree canopy walk, reinforcing the park's evolving role as a citywide destination and creating an opportunity to advance complementary family-oriented public amenities;
6. VanPlay, through Initiative P.1.3, identifies the design and construction of five additional fully accessible destination play areas throughout the city, in addition to the ongoing integration of accessible play features in parks, reflecting the Park Board's commitment to ensuring parks and recreation spaces welcome everyone and provide equitable access to inclusive experiences for residents of all ages and abilities; and
7. The Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation's 2023–2026 Capital Plan includes funding for a new playground at Queen Elizabeth Park, providing an existing capital framework through which this work may be advanced;
8. Universal communication access is a key component of truly inclusive public space, including for non-verbal individuals, educators, multilingual families, young children, and individuals with diverse communication needs, and can be supported through the use of accessible communication boards and inclusive learning tools in park environments.



THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED

- A. THAT the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation direct staff to undertake planning and feasibility work, within available funding in the approved 2023–2026 Capital Plan, for the development of Vancouver’s second destination sensory all-abilities park at Queen Elizabeth Park;
- B. THAT in undertaking this work, staff be directed to consider how the proposed inclusive sensory all-abilities park may complement existing, approved, and emerging destination amenities within Queen Elizabeth Park, including the proposed zipline and tree canopy walk;
- C. THAT staff be directed to identify and evaluate potential locations within Queen Elizabeth Park, giving preference to sites that:
 - i. provide convenient access for children, families, and caregivers of varying mobility levels;
 - ii. are in close proximity to public washroom facilities;
 - iii. are in close proximity to parking, including accessible parking;
 - iv. minimize impacts on significant horticultural, heritage, and viewscape features; and
 - v. can support a destination-quality play experience appropriate to the park’s citywide role, including consideration of nature-based and context-sensitive design approaches aligned with the park’s character;
- D. THAT staff be directed to undertake public and stakeholder engagement to inform both the preferred location and future play features of the proposed sensory all-abilities park, including engagement with families, park users, accessibility advocates, community organizations, and relevant advisory groups;
- E. THAT staff be directed to consider inclusive, destination-quality play features, including but not limited to accessible play components, sensory-rich play experiences, quiet or retreat spaces, accessible surfacing and pathways, inclusive swings, social play elements, and nature-integrated play opportunities appropriate to the Queen Elizabeth Park setting, and to incorporate universal communication access features as part of a pilot approach, including accessible communication boards designed to support non-verbal individuals, educators, multilingual families, and individuals with diverse communication needs; and
- F. THAT staff be directed to explore the implementation of accessible communication boards as a pilot initiative within the proposed park, in consultation with relevant experts and organizations including Forever Kind Learning Ltd. and others working in this field, to assess best practices for inclusive communication tools in public parks, including but not limited to Picture Assisted Communication (PAC), American Sign Language (ASL) supports, Braille integration, color-coded learning systems, and interactive communication features designed to foster accessibility and inclusion; and



- G. THAT staff report back to the Board via memo by July 27, 2026, on timelines and preliminary concept directions for both communication boards and inclusive play features for the proposed park, including potential approaches to implementing accessible communication boards as a pilot initiative within Queen Elizabeth Park.